VAISHALI MALGONDA PATIL, 42

Herwad *village*, *Kolhapur*

"In 2020, there were games for women in the village with the winners getting Paithani saris. I had bought two Paithanis to gift but wasn't allowed to give them to the winners on stage since I was a widow. It still hurts...we too have our dignity, they should ban practices that stigmatise us. The government must ensure social security for widows"



the young Puja Nitin Nalawade. The 28-year-old, who lost her husband four years ago, says she has begun wearing her mangalsutra again after the gram sabha resolution. She's also happy that, unlike in the past, her daughter will not feel sad at them having to skip the annual haldi-kumkum event organised by the mothers at her school.

Inspired by Kolhapur's example, other villages like Nagzari in Satara, Vaghalwadi and Kambleshwar in Pune's Baramati taluka, Dhamani in Sangli, and 29 villages around Khadakwasla near Pune city, have followed suit. "This is a peoples' movement and not a top-down movement. The people have realised that social evils have no place in a healthy society," says Karthikeyan S., CEO, zilla parishad, Kolhapur. The parishad has been organising workshops, training sessions and mass awareness campaigns under the 'Mission Shakti' programme to sensitise village heads, functionaries and residents.

other states as well. In 2023, the Goa government promised to introduce a law to prohibit discrimination against widows. The legislation has yet to happen, but some village panchayats in the state have approved resolutions in this regard. On June 11, 2024, the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) sent an advisory asking all states to rehabilitate widows, and also recommended a "suitable legislation to deal with the plight of abandoned widows, such as that against Sati *pratha*".

"This is a positive step. Some conventions can't be presumed to be healthy just because they were followed for ages...," says Aditi Tatkare, the minister for women and child development, Maharashtra, adding that her department will create a committee of ladies in every village to oversee the implementation of schemes, including rehabilitation of widows.



"It's a positive step [for widows]. Some customs can't be called healthy just because they were followed for ages..."

ADITI TATKARE, *Minister for women and child development, Maharashtra*

They tend to stand out without the kumkum or the mangalsutra, which draws unwelcome attention from some of the men. Such experiences further crush their confidence. The situation was begging for a change."

Mane and other gram panchayat members in Ambap worked on the plan for a year, counselling villagers to accept the resolution. Panchayat member Manik Dabhade says there was opposition initially from some quarters, but it gradually broke down and the motion was passed unanimously. Kavita Waghmode, 34, who lost her husband Tanaji to Covid three years ago, is one of those hoping life will turn a bit more normal in the coming days. She has had to take charge of their poultry farm since then, and the men looking at her "in a different manner" was only adding to her problems. It's the same with

A SILENT SHIFT

In 2022, the Uddhav Thackeray-led Maha Vikas Aghadi government issued a resolution during the Covid pandemic, urging an end to rituals that persecuted widows. State government estimates say that so far 7,683 villages and 1,182 municipal wards have come on board. In Kolhapur, 271 of the 1,026 panchayats have approved these resolutions, and Karthikeyan feels the district may be free of the scourge in another two years.

The movement to ensure dignity for widows has gained momentum in

Among those who have felt a load lift off their chests in the past few years is Prajakta Pawar of Mangaon, who lost her husband Santosh in 2022 to jaundice. She was one of the first to visibly benefit from the gram sabha's resolution. "The decision has helped us widows feel more secure, and I stress the word secure," says the 38-year-old. She still wears her mangalsutra and sindoor and is thankful for all the support, especially from her sisters-in-law. As she puts it, "The *aabhushan* (ornaments) belong to the woman and it has to be her call to decide if she wants to wear them or not." It may have come late, but more power to her and her sisters. ■